

FREE WHITE PAPER

Keeping the Schedule Full

How customers find you, book you and come back, with templates and a 12-month calendar you can use this week.

For independent auto repair shops with ten technicians or fewer.

XSite Auto xsiteauto.com

BEFORE YOU START

The easiest shop to find, trust and book wins.

Most new customers find a shop the same way. They search on their phone, look at the reviews, and book the shop that makes it easiest. The shops that win aren't always the best technicians. They're the ones customers can find, trust and book in a minute.

This white paper covers ten ways to keep your bays full, starting with the free ones. Each has a goal, the steps, the common mistakes and one number to track. None of it needs an advertising budget. Most of it takes less than an hour a week once it's set up.

At the back you'll find a 12-month calendar of seasonal offers, message templates you can copy, and a 30-minute weekly routine to keep it all going.

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Before you spend a dollar

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The free listing

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Word of mouth

Written alongside a working independent repair shop in Niagara, Ontario, run by a former Toyota master technician.

1 OF 10 · BEFORE YOU SPEND A DOLLAR

Know your numbers first

Most shops try to get busier without knowing where the gaps are. A few numbers tell you whether you need new customers, more visits from the ones you have, or simply fewer empty hours on certain days.

Goal: Know how many hours you have to sell, where your customers come from, and what a customer is worth.

THE STEPS

1. Work out the hours you have to sell each week: technicians × hours each works.
2. Track hours sold for a month, by day of the week. Quiet days show up fast.
3. Ask every new customer "How did you hear about us?" and write it down.
4. Work out what a customer is worth over time, not just on one visit.

AN EXAMPLE

Say a typical customer spends $600 a year with you and stays for five years:

$600 × 5 years = $3,000

That's what one new loyal customer is worth, and what one bad experience can cost.

COMMON MISTAKES

- Spending on advertising before fixing the leaks that lose customers you already have.
- Guessing where customers come from.

TRACK THIS

Hours sold ÷ hours available,
and new customers each month by where they came from.

In XSite Auto: The day schedule shows hours booked against hours available for each technician, and the Today screen shows labour hours billed this week.

2 OF 10 · THE FREE LISTING

Own your Google Business Profile

For most small shops, this free listing brings in more new customers than the website does. It's often the first thing a customer sees, and many decide from it alone.

Goal: When someone nearby searches for a repair shop, they find you, trust what they see, and can book in one tap.

THE STEPS

1. Claim the listing and verify it. Check that the name, address, phone and category are exactly right.
2. Keep your hours accurate, including holiday hours. Wrong hours lose customers and trust.
3. List your services in plain words, such as brake repair, oil change, check engine light, tires.
4. Add real photos of your shop, your bays and your team, and add a few new ones every season.
5. Add your booking link so customers can book straight from the listing.

COMMON MISTAKES

- An unclaimed listing with old hours and no photos.
- Stock photos instead of your real shop.

TRACK THIS

Calls, website visits and bookings
from your Google listing each month.

In XSite Auto: Every shop gets its own booking page you can link from your Google listing, Facebook or Instagram.

3 OF 10 · AT EVERY PICKUP

Ask for reviews, every day

Customers read reviews before they call. A shop with many recent reviews looks busy and trusted. A shop with a few old ones looks like a gamble, however good the work is.

Goal: A steady flow of recent, honest reviews, and a calm reply to every one.

THE STEPS

1. Ask in person at pickup, when the car is fixed and the customer is happy.
2. Make it easy: a short link by text or email, and a QR code at the counter.
3. Make asking part of the routine, so it happens every day, not when someone remembers.
4. Reply to every review. Thank people by name for good ones.
5. Reply to a bad review calmly, once, and offer to talk it through by phone. Future customers read the reply more than the complaint.

> *"Glad we could get you sorted. If you have a minute, a quick Google review really helps a small shop like ours. I'll text you the link."*

COMMON MISTAKES

- Asking only once in a while, in bursts.
- Arguing with a bad review in public.

TRACK THIS

Reviews asked for and reviews received,
each week.

In XSite Auto: Your Google reviews can show on your shop's website.

4 OF 10 · DAY AND NIGHT

Let customers book any time

Many people sort out their car in the evening, after work, when you're closed. If the only way to book is to call during the day, some of them never get around to it, and some book with whoever lets them do it online.

Goal: A customer who decides at 10 pm to book their car in can do it in a minute, without calling.

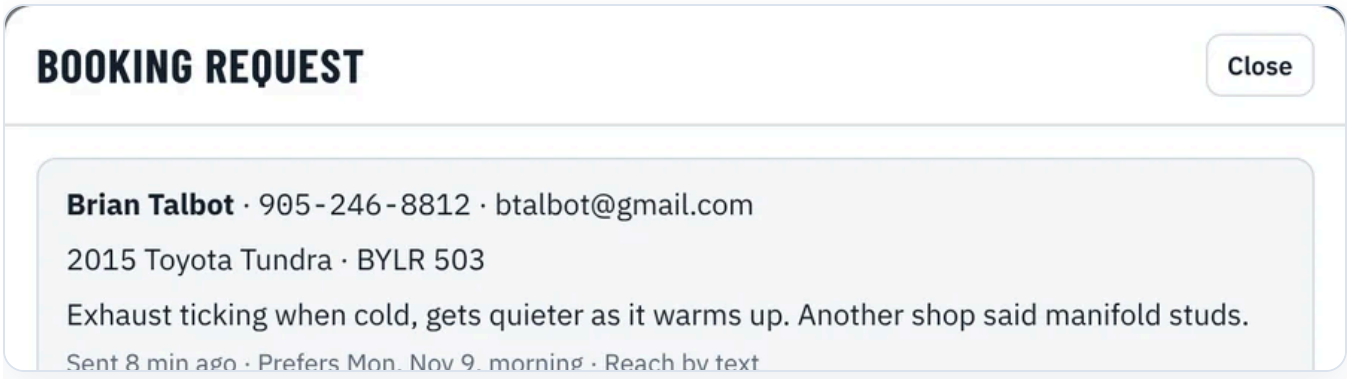
THE STEPS

1. Put a "Book online" button on your website, your Google listing and your Facebook page, and in your email signature.
2. Print a QR code for the counter and the window.
3. Decide which services can be booked online, and how many a day, so you stay in control.
4. Answer every online request the same morning to confirm the time.
5. Change your voicemail to tell callers they can book online.

COMMON MISTAKES

- A booking form that only sends an email, which then sits unread.
- Hiding the booking link on a back page of the website.

TRACK THIS **Online bookings each week,**
and how many came in after hours.



An online booking arrives with the vehicle and the concern already filled in.

In XSite Auto: Customers pick a service and a time from your website or booking page, and each request lands on your schedule.

5 OF 10 · ON A PHONE

A website that does one job well

Your website doesn't need to be fancy. Most visitors are on a phone, in a hurry, with a problem. They want to know if you can help, where you are, and how to book.

Goal: **On a phone, a customer can call, find you and book within five seconds.**

THE STEPS

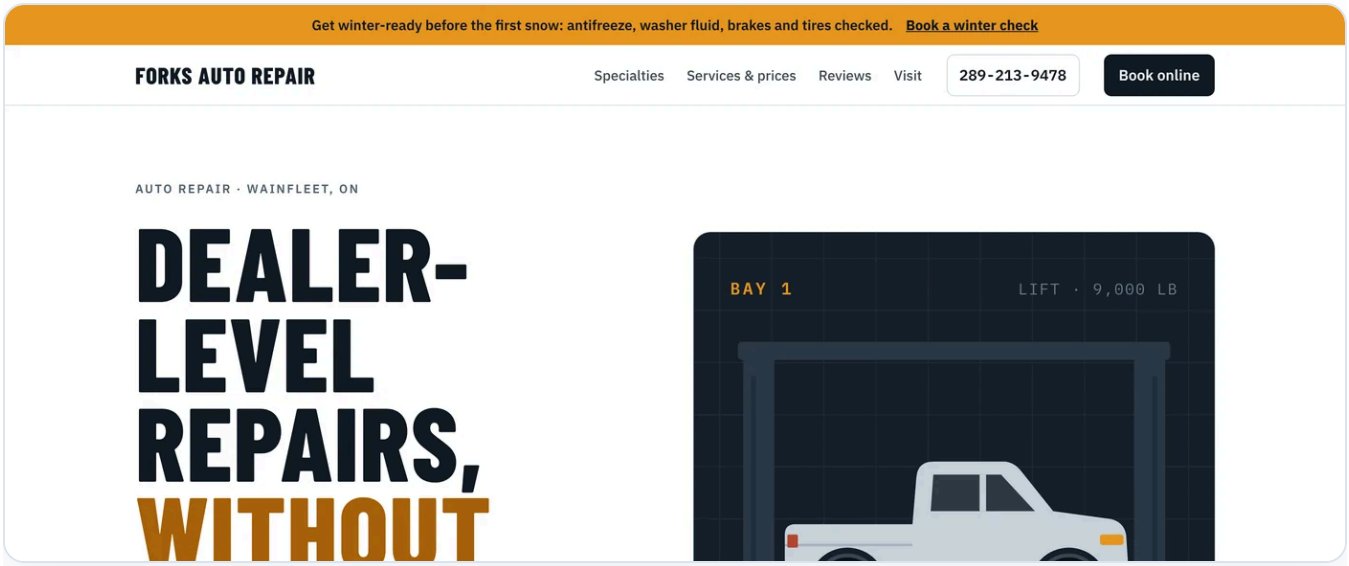
1. Put a tap-to-call phone number and a booking button at the top of every page.
2. Show your hours and address clearly, with a map link.
3. List your services in the words customers search for.
4. Keep a notice banner for holidays, closures and seasonal offers, and keep it current.
5. Make sure it loads fast on a phone. Check it on your own phone once a month.

COMMON MISTAKES

- An old website with last year's hours and a dead booking form.
- A home page full of text and no clear way to book.

TRACK THIS

Bookings and calls from the website,
each month.



A shop website with online booking built in.

In XSite Auto: Every shop can have a fast website with booking built in, and change the notice banner, hours, prices and specialties from inside the app.

6 OF 10 · THE DAY BEFORE

Cut no-shows with a reminder

A no-show is an empty bay you planned around. Most aren't rude. People simply forget. A reminder the day before catches almost all of them.

Goal: **Every booked customer shows up, or tells you in time to fill the slot.**

THE STEPS

1. Contact every customer the day before their appointment, by text or a quick call.
2. Ask them to confirm, so you know who's coming.
3. When someone can't make it, rebook them on the spot.
4. Offer the freed slot to a customer who wanted an earlier time, or call someone from your declined-work list.

> *"Hi [name], this is [shop]. Just a reminder that your appointment is tomorrow at [time] for your [vehicle]. Will you be able to make it? Reply YES or NO."*

AN EXAMPLE

Say two customers a week don't show for 1.5-hour jobs, at a $120 labour rate:

3 hours × $120 = $360 a week

That's about $18,700 a year in empty bay time.

COMMON MISTAKES

- Reminding only some customers, when someone has time.

TRACK THIS **No-shows each week.**

7 OF 10 · THE WARMEST LIST YOU HAVE

Bring customers back

Finding a new customer takes far more effort than bringing back one who already trusts you. Yet many shops never contact a customer again after they pick up their car.

Goal: Customers who've used you once come back for their next service, instead of going wherever is closest.

THE STEPS

1. Record every recommended repair the customer declined, with a price and how urgent it is.
2. Follow up on declined work in two to four weeks, and bring it up again at the next visit.
3. Keep each customer's mileage and last visit, and remind them when service is due.
4. Thank customers after a big job with a short note or email a few days later.
5. Every few months, look for good customers you haven't seen in a year, and get in touch.

> *"Last time you were in, we noticed your rear brakes were getting thin. We have an opening Thursday morning if you'd like to get them done before winter."*

COMMON MISTAKES

- Treating every visit as the last one.
- Following up so often that it feels like pressure.

TRACK THIS

Returning customers ÷ all customers,
each month.

In XSite Auto: Every customer's vehicles and visits are in one place, and your QuickBooks customer list comes over in minutes, so you start with your real list.

8 OF 10 · EVERY FEW MONTHS

Plan around the seasons

Repair work follows the calendar: tires and batteries before winter, air conditioning before summer, inspections before road trips. Shops that plan a few weeks ahead fill the schedule before the rush instead of turning people away during it.

Goal: **Busy seasons are planned for, and slow seasons have something to fill them.**

THE STEPS

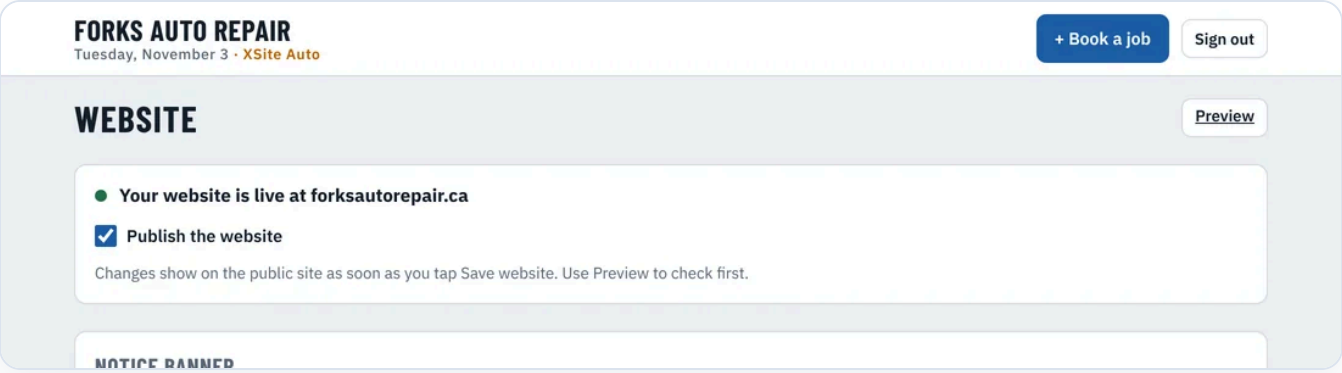
1. Pick one offer for each season (see the calendar at the back).
2. Start talking about it three to four weeks before the rush.
3. Use the same message everywhere: your website banner, Google listing, social media and the counter.
4. Contact past customers who are likely to need it, such as everyone you put winter tires on last year.
5. Use the slow weeks for jobs that can be planned, and offer them to customers who've been putting them off.

COMMON MISTAKES

- Starting the winter tire push the week of the first snow.
- Discounting during the busy season, when you'd be full anyway.

TRACK THIS

Bookings for the seasonal service,
compared with the same weeks last year.



Change the website notice banner for each season in a minute.

In XSite Auto: Change your website's notice banner, hours and prices yourself, any time, from your phone.

9 OF 10 · STEADY WORK

Be the shop local businesses call

Contractors, landscapers, delivery services and trades have vehicles that can't sit. They value speed and reliability more than the lowest price, and one good account can be worth dozens of individual customers.

Goal: A handful of local businesses rely on you for their vehicles and send steady work every month.

THE STEPS

1. List the businesses nearby that run vans, trucks or service vehicles.
2. Offer a simple account: priority booking, one monthly statement and a named contact.
3. Drop by with a card and a short letter. Follow up by phone a week later.
4. Agree on clear terms for the account in writing, including when payment is due.
5. Keep their vehicle history so you can remind them when service is due.

COMMON MISTAKES

- Offering big discounts instead of what fleets actually want: speed and reliability.
- Accounts with no written terms, which turn into old balances.

TRACK THIS

Business accounts,
and their share of monthly sales.

10 OF 10 · WORD OF MOUTH

Make it easy to recommend you

Word of mouth is still how most small shops grow. You can't buy it, but you can make it easier and thank the people who do it.

Goal: Happy customers and nearby businesses send people your way, and you thank them when they do.

THE STEPS

1. Get to know the tow operators, tire shops, body shops and dealers nearby. They send work to shops they trust.
2. Hand out a couple of business cards at pickup to happy customers.
3. Ask new customers who sent them, and thank that person with a call or a card.
4. Be visible locally: a sponsorship, a community event, a sign people can see from the road.

COMMON MISTAKES

- Never asking how new customers heard about you, so you never know who to thank.

TRACK THIS

New customers from referrals,
each month.

PLAN THE YEAR

A 12-month calendar

One focus a month. Start talking about each one three to four weeks early. Adjust the timing for your climate.

January	**Quiet-month specials**	Contact customers with declined work. Offer planned jobs like timing belts and brakes.
February	**Business accounts**	Visit local businesses with vans and trucks. Offer priority booking.
March	**Spring check**	Suspension and alignment after winter roads, wiper blades, a general inspection.
April	**Tire changeover**	Swap back to all-season tires. Book early to spread the rush.
May	**Air conditioning**	A/C checks before the first hot week.
June	**Road trip ready**	Pre-trip inspections before summer holidays.
July	**Reviews push**	Summer is busy: ask every customer for a review.
August	**Back to school**	Family vehicles before the school run starts.
September	**Pre-winter planning**	Tell customers winter booking is open. Contact last year's tire customers.
October	**Winter tires and batteries**	Tire changeovers, battery tests, wipers and coolant.
November	**Winter readiness**	Last call for tires. Fill gaps from the declined-work list.
December	**Thank-you month**	Thank your regulars and business accounts. Plan next year's offers.

COPY AND USE

Message templates

Short, friendly and in your own words. Change anything in brackets.

Review request, after pickup

Hi [name], thanks for choosing [shop] today. If you have a minute, a quick review really helps a small shop like ours: [review link]

Send within an hour of pickup.

Appointment reminder, the day before

Hi [name], this is [shop]. Reminder: your appointment is tomorrow at [time] for your [vehicle]. Will you be able to make it? Reply YES or NO.

Only text customers who agreed to receive texts, and include a way to opt out.

Declined work follow-up, two to four weeks later

Hi [name], it's [shop]. When you were in, we noticed [item] was getting close. We have time on [day] if you'd like to take care of it. Just reply or call [phone].

Seasonal offer

Winter's coming. [Shop] is booking tire changeovers now. Book online at [link] or call [phone]. Early spots go fast.

We haven't seen you in a while

Hi [name], it's been about a year since we last saw your [vehicle] at [shop]. If it's due for service, we'd be glad to see you again. Book at [link].

Thank you to a referrer

Hi [name], [new customer] told us you sent them our way. Thank you, we really appreciate it. See you next time. [Your name], [shop]

Reply to a bad review

Hi [name], I'm sorry your visit didn't go the way it should have. I'd like to hear more and make it right. Please call me directly at [phone]. [Your name], owner

PRINTABLE

The 30-minute weekly routine

Pick a quiet half hour, the same day every week. Week of: _____

- [ ] Reply to every new review, good and bad
- [ ] Check reviews asked for and received this week
  Asked: _____ Received: _____
- [ ] Check your Google listing: hours right, any questions to answer, a new photo if you have one
- [ ] Update the website banner if the season or an offer has changed
- [ ] Look at next week's schedule for empty hours
  Quiet days: _____
- [ ] Call or message five customers from the declined-work list
- [ ] Check no-shows this week, and that every appointment got a reminder
  No-shows: _____
- [ ] Write down where this week's new customers came from
  Google: ___ Referral: ___ Drive-by: ___ Other: ___
- [ ] Thank anyone who sent you a customer
- [ ] Check what's coming up on the 12-month calendar

Fill the schedule without the paperwork

XSite Auto gives your shop online booking from your website and Google listing, walk-in check-in, a website you can update from your phone, and every customer and vehicle in one place, built for shops with ten technicians or fewer.

$99 USD or $139 CAD a month after a free 14-day trial, with no credit card needed and no contract. Done-for-you setup is optional ($495 USD or $695 CAD, one time).

Start a free trial | **Book a 15-minute demo**

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